

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Aditya Natraj, Piramal Foundation

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact leaders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad. In this podcast, we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Aditya Natraj, Chartered Accountant, Economist, and MBA from INSEAD, and one of India's most consequential leaders in the field of public system transformation. Aditya is the CEO of Piramal Foundation, the philanthropic arm of the Piramal Group, which has impacted over 113 million lives across 27 states and two union territories in just over sixteen years. He is also the founder of the Kaivalya Education Foundation and the Piramal School of Leadership.

Neharika Vohra: Aditya's path to social impact is an unusual one. He trained as a chartered accountant, worked with KPMG for five years, then joined a technology startup in Europe before returning to India with a purpose: to address the staggering dropout crisis in Indian education. What followed was a decade and a half of building systems, training school principals, and working alongside state governments to unlock what Piramal Foundation calls Sewa Bhav — the spirit of service in government middle managers who deliver critical services to millions of citizens.

Neharika Vohra: Under Aditya's leadership, Piramal Foundation has partnered with NITI Aayog's Aspirational Districts Programme, worked with state governments across Rajasthan, Bihar, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and beyond, and built the Gandhi Fellowship as a pipeline for young leaders to engage with public systems. Piramal Foundation's work spans education, healthcare, livelihoods, climate and tribal development.

Neharika Vohra: Aditya is an Ashoka Fellow, an Echoing Green Fellow, and an Aspen India Fellow. He serves on the governing boards of the Quality Council of India, Akanksha Foundation, and BridgeSpan India, and was awarded the Times Now Amazing Indian Award in the Education category.

Neharika Vohra: Aditya, welcome to our podcast. It is indeed a privilege and an honour to have you here.

Aditya Natraj: Thank you so much, Neharika. I was wondering who you were describing — somewhere along the way it seemed like someone more than me.

Neharika Vohra: It's you, Aditya, because we've known each other for many years now. So, Aditya, we're going to talk to you both about the organisation, the cause, and you as a person. Let's start with a simple question: give us a picture of what Piramal Foundation looks like today — its scale, the range of domains it addresses, the geographies it operates in, and the nature of its government partnerships.

Aditya Natraj: Sure, let me try that. Like you mentioned in the introduction, we really do only one thing: enable government systems to deliver. In India, the army works, and we're all proud of that — it's a government system. The railways run on time. IITs and IIMs work, and they're government colleges too. But for some reason, when it comes to public health and public education, we assume the government system will never work — that you have to go to a private hospital, a private school. People fight with each other to get into Delhi University, but nobody fights to get their child into a public school. This is simply a historical accident — we never invested in the management processes, the systems, the outcome orientation, the strategic processes, the digitisation that the railways and the army did invest in.

Aditya Natraj: So our job is really to make people feel proud — I'm hoping my grandchildren will feel as proud of coming out of a government school as they would of coming out of an IIT today. That's all we do: we help governments, we enable governments, in public health and public education. About 80% of our work is in these two sectors, and we do some work in gender, climate and water as well. Within that, roughly 80% of our work is concentrated in the east of India — Jharkhand, Assam, Chhattisgarh, Odisha and Bihar. Instead of BIMARU, we call it JACOB — Jharkhand, Assam, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Bihar.

Aditya Natraj: These five states between them have 26% of India's people in poverty, compared with just 12% in the rest of the country, and the income disparity is worsening: in 2011 the rest of India's per capita income was 1.6 times that of these states; by 2021 it had grown to 2.2 times. The sad reality is that philanthropy and CSR should logically flow more heavily to these states because they're further behind — but the per capita philanthropy reaching them is less than 20% of what flows to the rest of India. So we are deliberately over-indexed on these five states, helping their government systems deliver better health and education outcomes.

Neharika Vohra: Interesting. And because you enable government systems to work well, I'm assuming you work largely, or only, in partnership with government — through some kind of MoU. Is that how it functions?

Aditya Natraj: Yes, that's right. Other people might open a hospital; we will never open a hospital — we pick up an existing government hospital and improve it. Other people might open a school; we will never open a school — we pick up a set of a hundred, or a thousand, government schools and work out how to improve them. Other people might recruit and deploy new teachers; we will never do that — we ask who the existing thirty thousand teachers in Jharkhand are, and how we can help improve their capacity and motivation.

Aditya Natraj: Everything we do is about making government systems work. We believe the fundamental premise of democracy is that everyone should have an equal chance — and education and health are the two great levellers. I might be born to a poor family, or my grandmother might have had TB and I went to a poor school — either way, those two things shape everything else. So those are the two areas we focus on.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. And at the scale you've already established — 113 million lives across 27 states — how do you even think about measuring impact?

Aditya Natraj: We don't measure project-level impact, because we're not running our own schools or hospitals — we can't say '22% of my children got a first class,' because they aren't ours to claim. Our impact, effectively, is how India's HDI is doing. Every three years, when the National Family Health Survey reports that maternal mortality in Bihar has fallen from 212 to 180 per lakh, some portion of that is possibly attributable to us. When the National Achievement Survey shows Rajasthan moving from 62% to 73% of children reading at grade level, we believe some portion of that is ours too. We measure ourselves the way governments measure themselves — think of how Accenture or McKinsey would think about a client's success as their own success. We look at it in a similar way.

Neharika Vohra: That's interesting. You started off in 2008 by founding the Kaivalya Education Foundation with specific training for school principals — itself an unusual intervention at the time — and from there you moved to what you just described: full public-system transformation. What led to that pivot, and how did it evolve?

Aditya Natraj: You're bringing back a lot of memories. I think there were three or four inflection points. We started off believing that the leadership of middle managers was key, and that's still around 40% of what we do today. You start out as a great teacher, but the person promoted to headmaster in government gets no training at all — you could be an excellent physics teacher and a terrible manager, because managing people is a completely different game. It's the same story with an excellent gynaecologist who's suddenly made head of a department but has no idea how to handle politics, project management, or people's motivation. The processes by which government selects, incentivises and builds the capacity of its middle managers were very weak, and that's what we set out to change. If Infosys selected people the way government does, Infosys wouldn't be what it is today. So that's where we started, and it's still the majority of our work today — except now it isn't only for headmasters; it's for district education officers, block education officers, cluster resource coordinators — everyone we call middle managers, in health as well as education. We train the chief medical officer, the civil surgeon, the block-level health officer; in the women and child department, we train the CDPO who runs ICDS and preschool work; in agriculture and minority affairs, we train the middle managers there too.

Aditya Natraj: As we worked in education, we realised middle managers were failing — not for lack of capability, but because they didn't have the right information to make the right decision at the right time. If I don't know how many teachers are in a school, what subjects they can teach, or how they've performed in the past, because all of that sits in manual records, I can't make a sound decision about a teacher transfer — it becomes arbitrary. So we started digitising education. In Delhi, it would take seven layers of approval above a woman just to grant her one day's casual leave — so we digitised processes for teacher transfers, leave, medical reimbursement, everything, to remove that administrative burden and free people up for higher-value work. We did the same digitisation in health — knowing how many TB patients there are, which pregnancies are high-risk, which drugs are in stock, which X-ray machines are working — so government could take better decisions and allocate resources more efficiently.

Aditya Natraj: That was the second layer on top of leadership. About eight years ago we added a third layer: community engagement. We realised the point at which government fails is where the last-mile government worker — a teacher or an ASHA worker — and the first-mile citizen — a sarpanch — don't know how to engage with each other. It's a condescending approach from the state, and an adversarial one from the community, and unless that engagement improves, education, health and agriculture all fail. You can have a brilliant idea in agriculture or water conservation, but if the village won't listen to you, nothing moves. Sarpanches like building roads and installing water tankers, but tell them they can be involved in health and education and they say, no, that's the doctor's job, the teacher's job — when in fact a sarpanch can organise the community to isolate a TB

patient, or arrange a vehicle where there's no ambulance, or convince families that girls deserve to study through class 12 just as much as boys. So we built a third stack: training public systems to engage meaningfully with communities.

Aditya Natraj: The fourth and most recent stack is inclusion. We realised that three groups struggle most to engage with government systems: minority religious communities, tribal populations, and Scheduled Castes. These populations use public services less because they feel demeaned when they access them — and that's a cultural issue, not just a matter of individual leadership. The word "tribal" itself carries an assumption that needs unlearning; you're inducted into a system that tells you these people need to be "uplifted." So the fourth stack is about shifting public systems to empathise with these populations and the choices they make. None of this is revolutionary — talent and digitisation are what an Accenture would do to help a company; community engagement is the equivalent of customer engagement; inclusion is what's become the DEI agenda in the corporate world. We're simply applying the same principles businesses use to become better, to the social sector — specifically to public systems.

Neharika Vohra: That raises so many questions. Everyone talks about digitisation today, but you were doing it years before it became fashionable in the corporate world. What interests me more is how you built an organisation capable of doing all four of these things — leadership training, digitisation, and especially community engagement and inclusion, which are much harder. How did you make this a reality?

Aditya Natraj: I can tell you're an OD professor, because nobody has ever asked me this quite this way before — but it's something we grapple with constantly. People who understand leadership development don't understand leadership development for the public sector; it's an entirely different animal. In our early years, we even worked with the Ravi Matthai Centre, tried transactional analysis, and it flopped completely with government headmasters, even though it works well in the private sector. We had six or seven PhDs in the room trying things, and we kept failing. What's worked for us is listening to governments — listening, failing, apologising, and reinventing, again and again, until we found what actually worked for them. You can't just hire people who already know how to do this; you need people with a genuine learner's mindset and real humility, willing to say 'I don't know,' even if they're experts elsewhere.

Aditya Natraj: It's the same with digitisation. Corporates resist digitisation too, but there you can eventually remove someone who won't comply, and corruption in corporates rarely approaches what's possible in government. Once you digitise a government system, you create accountability — and that's what people resist, not the technology itself. You can bring in Infosys or TCS for the technical architecture, but the change management is a completely different skill, and we had to build people internally who understood the nuances of change management inside government.

Aditya Natraj: It's the same again with community engagement. You can take a bunch of social workers, but knowing how to run an activist campaign is nothing like the constructive role needed to work with a last-mile government worker — you'd end up simply siding with one party, shouting that tribal voices have never been heard, rather than actually bringing people together. So across all four areas, the pattern has been the same: we find a capability gap that doesn't exist anywhere else in India, and that's what excites us — then we spend five to ten years patiently building a team that knows how to do it.

Neharika Vohra: Tell me more about the kind of people who've stuck, and how you've invested in their development so they could deliver what was needed.

Aditya Natraj: The best person we have doing leadership development is a mathematics honours graduate from Lady Shri Ram College — you'd never have guessed that. Most of us choose our degrees based on our parents' misaligned incentives anyway, so the degree itself doesn't matter much. What we look for are two or three key traits. The first is whether you're a learner or an expert — anyone who believes they already know the answer, we simply can't absorb, because if the answer were known, the problem wouldn't still exist for us to solve. The second is humility — many people are afraid to admit failure, but we celebrate it; we call it the 'incredible loops,' because you keep failing and have to persist through it. The third is what we call Seva Bhav — a genuine interest in serving the population you work with, not a sense that you're doing them a favour. A lot of people join NGOs believing they're 'giving back,' but that's not quite right — you're not giving back, you're learning; the community is giving you the opportunity to make your life meaningful, and you're getting more than you're giving.

Aditya Natraj: We select for these three traits, reinforce them through our internal processes, and reward people who score highly on them in our promotions. In fact, our performance evaluation has an x-axis for what you achieved, and a y-axis for how you achieved it — your final grade depends on both, because sometimes success comes on the first attempt and sometimes it takes three or five years of failure before it lands. Someone who eventually succeeds through resilience and humility is more likely to repeat that success — and is therefore more valuable to the country — than someone who simply got lucky and can't explain how.

Neharika Vohra: You've clearly codified this in your performance management. Is selection codified too, or is it something your interviewers have simply absorbed over time?

Aditya Natraj: We have five thousand people, so there's no way I can personally select everyone — everything has to be codified. We make a set of mistakes, step back, codify what we've learned, make the next set of mistakes, and codify again. Every time you think you've found the holy grail, you realise there isn't one — life is just a continuous process. But yes, there is a formal framework.

Neharika Vohra: Do you have a dedicated HR team for this?

Aditya Natraj: Yes, we do. Most of the work we do internally is about building internal leadership so people can then exercise external leadership. On day one, every new joiner spends three days on Marshall Rosenberg's non-violent communication, and another three days on 'influence without authority.' Everything we do depends on this, because you can't influence a sarpanch you have no power over, or a middle manager, using a title or prior expertise — none of that helps. We once had a Delhi School of Economics graduate tell me, 'I studied all this economics, but I still couldn't convince one woman to open a bank account.' Knowing finance matters, but influencing a woman to open a bank account and start saving is an entirely different skill. So non-violent communication, influence without authority, and social-emotional literacy are three things we invest in heavily, with dedicated tools, processes and incentives.

Neharika Vohra: If you had to estimate, what percentage of your effort goes into hiring and training people to be performance-ready? My sense is it's higher than most organisations.

Aditya Natraj: Very high, because the people we need simply aren't available elsewhere — we are, in effect, a training organisation. Our Gandhi Fellows, for instance, are the last-mile of our work: freshly graduated from a bachelor's or master's programme, somewhere between 21 and 27 years old, roughly a third each from science, commerce and arts backgrounds. Nobody in India is trained to work with real emotional literacy — most people, asked what they're feeling, will say 'happy' or 'sad,' but to genuinely understand the mother in front of you who's forcing her daughter into an early marriage, or the government officer choosing corruption, you need a much more nuanced understanding of your own emotions first. Unless you're aware of what's happening inside yourself, you can't read what's happening in the other person, name it for them, or help them process it and make a different choice.

Aditya Natraj: Two thousand of our five thousand people are Gandhi Fellows, and they join for two years and then move on — which means roughly 40% of the organisation turns over regularly, and we have to keep training people afresh. Our view is that as long as the skill stays in the wider ecosystem, the investment is still valuable, so we think of ourselves as a training organisation first. Even the staff who support the Fellows haven't typically engaged with public systems at this scale before — someone might be a brilliant physics teacher, or good at training twenty private-sector teachers, but working across a thousand schools is a different order of magnitude altogether. A great deal of effort goes into building that capability.

Neharika Vohra: Looking back at how this has evolved, is there anything you'd do differently?

Aditya Natraj: Everything, honestly. If I'd known how much effort this would take, I probably wouldn't have started. It's enormous work — we're still steeped in patriarchy and casteism, and there are people who join us genuinely believing that getting into Shri Ram College had nothing to do with privilege, only hard work. Unless that belief is unwound, when that person walks into a classroom of tribal children, he'll assume they simply didn't work as hard as he did — he won't see the privilege of opportunity at all. So you have to retrain, unlearn and relearn, or that person can't genuinely serve the country. We didn't realise how much personal work that would take, both on ourselves and on our teams — dismantling a part of your own identity that you've held onto for years, and needing real support while that happens.

Aditya Natraj: We've had many ex-corporate joiners — people with twenty-five years of success, who grew a retail business from zero to a thousand crores — who simply can't imagine that they're about to fail here, and for perhaps three years they won't be useful until they've unlearned enough. The first time you fail, your ego says something's wrong outside you; the second time, something's wrong with your boss; the third time, something's wrong with the organisation; the fourth, something's wrong with the strategy. Only after about eighteen months does it finally arrive at 'I don't know how to do this, and I need to learn' — and then you go through another eighteen-month cycle of 'it's not possible,' 'it's not worth it,' 'it's too much effort,' before finally reaching a place of quiet persistence: I am merely a process, I'll do what I need to do, and the world will take care of itself. Holding people — senior, middle, and junior alike, whether they're joining at twenty, thirty, or forty-five — through that cycle, again and again, is a huge amount of work.

Neharika Vohra: And how many people are we talking about at the senior end — five hundred, eight hundred?

Aditya Natraj: If you split our five thousand people by band, there are about fifty people in Band 4, the most senior band; roughly 250 in Band 3; and about 1,500 in Band 1 — which is where the two thousand or so I mentioned earlier come from.

Neharika Vohra: And of course, many of your people are remote — you're based between Mumbai and Delhi, but your teams are spread across 27 states. There's no real face-to-face culture in the usual sense.

Aditya Natraj: Exactly, and that's a critical point. When we tried to borrow corporate practices, we realised they simply didn't translate — ICICI Bank can have three thousand people in one building, celebrate a birthday, sense a colleague's mood in the corridor. I might have three or four people at most sharing a block, and a block can span a hundred kilometres. So in the morning, one person heads north to one village, another heads east to a different one — there's no shared office culture possible at all. Someone should write a PhD on how you build culture in a space where people can never actually observe their supervisor, because so much of culture is built simply by watching how people interact — and here, that's structurally impossible, all the way down to the last mile, where even four people working together are each headed to a different institution: one to the hospital, one to the Krishi Kendra, one to the ICDS centre, one to a teacher training session. So our systems have had to be built around a largely virtual culture from the start — which, oddly, means where senior leadership physically sits barely matters, because nobody at any level can really watch anybody else. It's also taught us a lot of humility about why government itself is so difficult to run: if we, with all our flexibility and training, still find this hard, it's no wonder public systems struggle.

Neharika Vohra: On a related note — motivation and compensation. How do you keep your teams motivated, especially given that compensation in the social sector is rarely the highest available?

Aditya Natraj: We developed a framework for this quite early, around year five or six, and it's held for roughly twelve years now. We call it MLJP — Meaning, Learning, Joy, and Pride. Money is there simply to put food on the table; beyond that, my job as a leader is to make sure people have MLJP. Meaning: the action you're doing every day — saving girls, helping India become more inclusive — has to carry personal significance for you; we draw a lot on Viktor Frankl's work here, because without meaning, there's no real drive. So when you think about compensation, you're not just thinking in financial terms — would you take a role worth 80% of another job's pay, if it carried 20% more meaning? Would you take 60%, if it offered you far more learning — genuine learning, about something the world doesn't yet know how to do, because if it did, we'd have already solved it?

Aditya Natraj: Then there's Joy — the emotional awareness that comes from learning to serve others is, to me, a particularly beautiful kind of joy, and if that appeals to you, you'll happily take a pay cut to do this work; if you're comfortable with a more transactional, mechanical existence and material gains feel like enough, that's fine too, but this probably isn't the right place for you. I still remember a headmaster telling me, 'Sir, for the first time, my wife spoke to me with love' — because he'd finally learned intimacy and vulnerability, which meant he could speak to his own wife differently, and she could respond in kind. You have to build that capacity in yourself before you can help a headmaster build it in his own life.

Aditya Natraj: And finally, Pride — living a life aligned with your values, in service of the country. Most of us have grandparents who did something meaningful for the nation, and independence itself was really Ambedkar's promise of an equal country — a promise still very much unfinished. If the idea of building a plural, democratic country excites you, this work is extraordinary; if it doesn't, it simply won't work for you. So MLJP gives people a framework to keep discovering these things about themselves — and if none of the four resonate, if the world feels purely transactional to you, this probably isn't the right organisation.

Neharika Vohra: Given the nature of this work, you can't be self-sustaining — you're dependent on external funders and a wide range of stakeholders. How do you manage those relationships, and what would you want others in the social sector to learn from it?

Aditya Natraj: About 70% of what I do, and much of what our senior leadership does, is fundraising. It's easy to see that as painful, but the deeper truth is that India's problems persist because Samaj, Sarkar and Bazaar — society, government and market — don't speak the same language. Just as we've had to understand how government makes its choices, we have to understand how capital makes its choices too. It's very easy to say society is virtuous while government and the market are both corrupt, and to position yourself as the only moral actor in the room — but that gets you nowhere. Society, government and the market are the three legs any society stands on, and our role in civil society is to bring them together, so the surplus the market creates can help government serve society better. Every time I help one more capitalist understand why investing in India's future is good for his own long-term interest, and why quality genuinely serves him too, that becomes its own form of MLJP for me.

Neharika Vohra: One added challenge for you is that you need patient capital — funders willing to stay in for the long haul rather than pulling out after a disappointing first year. What's helped you attract that kind of capital?

Aditya Natraj: It's certainly easier to raise money if you're building a named school, a named hospital, or a named scholarship. But the difficult work is exactly what we're meant for — if you wanted easy work, you wouldn't have started this in the first place. My advice is to find people in your own tribe who care about this experiment of building a plural democracy. I'm genuinely fascinated by the idea that 1.45 billion people, speaking 32 official languages, across multiple religions, can still coexist — I think in 400 years, people will look back and say what an audacious goal this was. China hasn't attempted it; the US hasn't; Europe can't

even hold together at 350 million people. We're attempting something extraordinary, and if we succeed, we'll have built a genuine model of plural, democratic coexistence for the world. If you find donors who share that excitement, they can't easily walk away, because everywhere else they look, they'll only see charity — not this. So the first step is anchoring the conversation at the level of what kind of country we're building, not just the specific programme. We invest heavily, even in our own internal training, in understanding plurality and democracy, and why India chose this path — because if you don't genuinely believe it matters, you shouldn't be in this organisation at all; and if you do, you carry that belief into every government servant, every sarpanch, every capitalist you meet.

Neharika Vohra: Let's turn to you as an individual, and your leadership. I know you wouldn't have lasted at KPMG given what motivates you — but I'm sure there have been highs and lows along the way. What's kept you going through all of it?

Aditya Natraj: It's changed over time. I'd say there have been three, maybe four distinct phases. The first was pure ego — an arrogant belief that there couldn't be a problem I couldn't wrap my mind around. A close friend once told me, 'You don't actually care about children, or about India — you're just so intellectually arrogant you can't accept there's a problem you can't solve.' That was painfully insightful. The second phase became more about identity: what else was even worth doing? Going back to KPMG, or to 'the real world' as my parents kept urging, just wasn't exciting enough anymore. But I don't think any of that is sustainable unless you eventually do genuine spiritual work — until you realise you're just cosmic dust circling a planet, giving yourself far too much importance, and that the only real purpose is service and love. This work forces that on you, because you have to learn to love the person spewing hatred at a Maulana, the person cynically abusing someone who reports to him, the capitalist who believes he alone holds all the knowledge in the world — you have to learn to love these people and bring them together. That's been such an extraordinary test of whether you can genuinely love everyone around you, and I think I'm on that path now, which is why I feel far more sustainable today — it's like a game that keeps unlocking the next level, and the next.

Neharika Vohra: Beautifully put — that everything eventually comes down to connection, relationship, and the capacity to love beyond yourself. One last question: what's your plan for succession? How are you thinking about institutional continuity, since that's often where growth and scalability quietly break down?

Aditya Natraj: Since we're a leadership-development organisation, it would be a bit embarrassing if I hadn't thought this through myself. I know the top 150 people in the organisation well, and I already know, informally, who the backup is for almost every senior role — enough that each person could step up when needed. I'm 52 now, and I know roughly ten to fifteen people in their early forties who I hope will take up this mantle in seven or eight years. Of that group, some may not pan out; some will succeed but may carry a somewhat different set of values than I'd consider ideal — the board watches this closely, as do I — but I'm genuinely excited about my own succession, because I believe two or three of them are simply better than I am: more energy, more commitment to the country. I'm looking forward to the day I can step back and let them take over.

Aditya Natraj: One thing a mentor taught me early on has stayed with me: the day you step into a role, start looking for your successor — even before you formally take the position. You need to know your two-downs extremely well, because over a five-to ten-year term, your two-down becomes your one-down, and eventually becomes you. I know the top fifty people in the organisation well enough to know which of the six or eight who report to me directly are likely to step up next.

Neharika Vohra: Who have been some of your own mentors along this journey?

Aditya Natraj: There was a professor at IIM who ran our very first internal leadership workshop — I don't know if you've heard of her, a lady called Neharika Vohra. She came in and, quite simply, told the eight of us in our first management-team meeting that we were all idiots. We've been fortunate to always have someone working closely with us — you did it for our first leadership team, when we were still a ten- or twelve-person organisation; then a second person worked with us for four or five years; a third for six or seven. Their role has always been to track our top hundred people, watch who's emerging into the next level, monitor the culture — and today we have someone named Sonali doing that work; I spoke with her just yesterday. There's always been someone mentoring us from outside, challenging how we think, triangulating our perceptions of each other, and keeping our egos from building grand illusions about ourselves.

Neharika Vohra: So you need someone external to help you stay honest about the work.

Aditya Natraj: At an absolute minimum, yes. Even a board member can be managed around, if I'm honest — but you need someone continually auditing these things. I've found I need someone walking alongside me throughout. In fact, most of our senior leaders have a formal structure of a counsellor, a coach, a mentor, and a buddy. All of us carry some unresolved childhood experience that needs a counsellor to work through; all of us have specific skill gaps — I'm not naturally good at delegation, or strategic clarity, or presence — that need a coach; all of us need a mentor who cares about us as a person, not as an economic contributor, inside the organisation or outside it; and all of us need a buddy simply to vent to. We formally build that architecture so people can keep growing.

Neharika Vohra: Are these buddies from within the organisation, or outside?

Aditya Natraj: Either is possible — I have buddies outside as well — but inside the organisation, we deliberately pair people from different teams, so it never becomes entangled with internal politics. They typically meet on Saturday mornings for half an hour, and it takes a little time to find that rhythm, but eventually it becomes a space where you can each admit, ‘I don’t know how to do this either,’ which helps everyone learn.

Neharika Vohra: We have many young people listening to this podcast — perhaps a chartered accountant, an MBA, or a management student considering a move from the corporate world into the social sector. What two or three things would you tell them to keep in mind?

Aditya Natraj: Honestly, I’m not very good at giving young people advice — I learn more from them than the other way round. They’ve grown up in such a different context from mine; I had to take out a housing loan, I barely had connectivity, I used to listen to a weekly radio digest and imagine I understood the world. They have so much more information available to them, and their world will have AI, climate change, and geopolitics I never had to reckon with at their age — so any rule I apply from my own experience may simply not hold for them.

Aditya Natraj: At a more philosophical level, the only thing I’ve told my own daughter is to invest in her spiritual and psychological development — I don’t think that can go wrong, whatever else in the world changes. I learned that lesson later than I wish I had, but everything else, I suspect, these young people will figure out in their own way.

Neharika Vohra: That’s genuinely useful advice, and I think it’s a wonderful note to close on. Thank you so much — this has been a delightful conversation, and a refreshing one, since it’s been a while since we last spoke. I hope more people are drawn to this kind of work, and that we all continue learning from you and the others building this kind of value. Thank you.

Aditya Natraj: Thank you for creating this. I always believed social-sector leadership deserved this kind of attention — I actually burned my MBA textbooks two years into working in the social sector, because so much of that thinking assumes every human being is optimising purely for themselves, and if you use that as your starting paradigm, the social sector simply doesn’t make sense. Why does anyone volunteer? We don’t really understand it in the corporate world — why do we have a hundred thousand volunteers at any given time, wanting nothing in return? I think what you’re doing here, trying to decode that, is a genuinely beautiful exercise, and I hope it helps.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely — and you’ve helped us with a small part of it. Thank you so much.